

failed bid for the Pune IPL team. The Pawars' defence is that the bid was made by City Corporation's managing director Anirudh Deshpande in his individual capacity and not for the firm. Deshpande, too, stated that he had used the company documents merely to show his personal worth.

Suddenly, almost a month after the IPL imbroglio had died down, it has been revived again with sustained media leaks targeting the NCP leader. Since his supremacy within the BCCI is unchallenged, Pawar's supporters suspect that this salvo has more to do with politics and less to do with cricket. As Pawar himself stated sarcastically, "I was somebody in that organisation (BCCI). Had I wanted it, do you think City Corporation would have lost the bid?" According to an NCP

leader, a section of the Maharashtra Congress is gunning for Pawar. Sonia's apathy to him is well-known and some Congress leaders often target him to curry favour with 10 Janpath. As Pawar's one-time strategic friend Bal Thackeray gloated, "Pawar cannot escape as the Congress has cornered him and the person behind it is Sonia Gandhi."

Interestingly, on June 8, a day before Pawar underwent a minor surgery, Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee paid him a visit. Apart from enquiring about his health, he also discussed cabinet issues such as the Government's plans to deregulate petrol prices. As far as governance is concerned, Pawar is a valuable friend. And in Maharashtra, he is still a force. In the 2009 state polls, the

Congress won only 47 per cent of the seats it contested while the NCP won 54 per cent. The Congress couldn't bully Pawar on portfolio distribution in the state Cabinet. A weakened Pawar only helps the Congress chief minister in Maharashtra to consolidate his position. The Congress is also not happy with NCP gimmicks such as inviting Amitabh Bachchan for the Bandra-Worli Sealink inauguration.

Apart from trying to weaken him in his home state, the Congress also knows that Pawar derives a lot of his clout from the BCCI, which is a powerful blend of politics and cricket. The Maratha leader is also the designate chief for the International Cricket Council and is tipped to take over next year. Any controversy, particularly in the cricketing world, could lead to an international embarrassment for Pawar.

Already his credibility in the cricketing circles has been dampened after BCCI president and a staunch Pawar loyalist, Shashank Manohar, refused to endorse his claim that Deshpande had bid for the Pune team. NCP sources say that Manohar's stand is more against Lalit Modi, the former IPL commissioner, than anti-Sharad Pawar. That Pawar has not totally disowned the former IPL commissioner rankles with most of the BCCI and some Congressmen.

This is not the first time that the Congress has used cricket to humble Pawar. In 2004, soon after he joined the UPA, Pawar said in a TV interview that he would not have joined the coalition had Sonia been made the prime minister. Though he was only reiterating the NCP's founding rationale—that it was opposed to a foreign-born person becoming prime minister—it infuriated the Congress leadership. The Grand Old Party hit back a few months later when Pawar made a bid for BCCI presidency and the Congress asked all its members in affiliated state units not to vote for Pawar. He lost. Clearly, in the UPA, it is not always easy to draw the dividing line between friend and foe. ■

NO LOVE LOST

A decade-old animosity between the Congress and the NCP leadership is reflected in their rocky alliance

THE NCP- IPL CONNECTION

The Congress is visibly uncomfortable with two NCP Union ministers' connections with franchises that bid for the IPL teams. But it cannot do anything about an ally.

SPIRALLING PRICES

Congress leaders took potshots at Pawar for rising food prices until he pointed out in exasperation that it was the "collective responsibility" of the entire Cabinet.

MINORITY ATTACK

Pawar recently took a dig at the Congress when he said that some "big parties with 150 years of experience" tend to take the minorities for granted.

PRIME MINISTERIAL AMBITIONS

In the run up to E-2009, Pawar emerged as a possible prime ministerial candidate with regional leaders from Mulayam Singh Yadav to Bal Thackeray endorsing him.

TURF WAR FOR MAHARASHTRA

In the 2009 state polls, the Congress first wanted the NCP to merge with it. It refused. The Congress won 47% of the 174 seats it contested. The NCP won 54% of its 114 seats.